

To Build a Fire

Jack London · 1908

First published: The Century, Aug 1908

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Lost_Face_(London_collection)/To_build_a_Fire (revision 16231138), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does To Build a Fire suggest about nature's indifference?
- What does To Build a Fire suggest about instinct versus reason?
- What does To Build a Fire suggest about pride?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* To Build a Fire	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*nature's indifference* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to To Build a Fire

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Jack London's life or times connects to nature's indifference in “To Build a Fire”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (nature's indifference, instinct versus reason, pride).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Jack London was born in San Francisco on 12 January 1876 and grew up poor in Oakland, working in a cannery, as an oyster pirate and as a sailor, and riding the rails as a hobo. In 1897 he joined the Klondike Gold Rush in the Yukon; he found no gold but found his subject. The Call of the Wild (1903) made him one of the best-paid writers in the world. A socialist and adventurer, he wrote some 50 books before his death at his California ranch on 22 November 1916.

Historical and cultural context

The story is set on the Yukon Trail during the Klondike Gold Rush (1896–99), where temperatures can fall below −50°F. London went to the Klondike in 1897 and nearly died of scurvy.

Publication and reception, then and now

The best-known version was published in The Century Magazine in August 1908; an earlier, quite different version for boys appeared in The Youth's Companion in 1902, in which the man survives.

Then: Widely read.

Now: A classic of naturalism, studied for man-versus-nature conflict and its indifferent universe.

Overview (spoiler-free)

An unnamed newcomer sets out alone, with only a husky dog, to walk to a mining camp on a day of extreme cold, ignoring an old-timer's warning.

Main themes

- humanity versus nature.
- instinct versus intelligence.
- pride.

Why it matters

It is a model of naturalism and of suspense from a simple plot, and a reminder to respect nature.

Spoilers · teacher only

He falls through ice, gets his feet wet, and fails to keep a fire going; he freezes to death, and the dog goes on to the camp.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open To Build a Fire: Have you ever ignored good advice? What happened?
Prompt: Before we open To Build a Fire: Have you ever ignored good advice? What happened?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
naturalism; conflict (man vs. nature); third-person omniscient; foreshadowing.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Jack London was born in San Francisco on 12 January 1876 and grew up poor in Oakland, working in a cannery, as an oyster pirate and as a sailor, and riding the rails as a hobo. In 1897 he joined the Klondike Gold Rush in the Yukon; he found no gold but found his subject. The Call of the Wild (1903) made him one of the best-paid writers in the world. A socialist and adventurer, he wrote some 50 books before his death at his California ranch on 22 November 1916. The world of the book. The story is set on the Yukon Trail during the Klondike Gold Rush (1896–99), where temperatures can fall below –50°F. London went to the Klondike in 1897 and nearly died of scurvy. Publication and reception. The best-known version was published in The Century Magazine in August 1908; an earlier, quite different version for boys appeared in The Youth's Companion in 1902, in which the man survives. Then: Widely read. Now: A classic of naturalism, studied for man-versus-nature conflict and its indifferent universe.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says the man's trouble was that he lacked imagination. Next, craft. I notice the flat, certain sentence, like a verdict. The strongest word is "trouble": it is a mild word for a deadly flaw, which creates irony. Then, effect. Why does London state the man's flaw so early? My answer: Telling us early turns the story into watching a man walk toward a death we can see coming.

> *The trouble with him was that he was without imagination (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says the man's trouble was that he lacked imagination. Next, craft. I notice the flat, certain sentence, like a verdict. The strongest word is "trouble": it is a mild word for a deadly flaw, which creates irony. Then, effect. Why does London state the man's flaw so early? My answer: Telling us early turns the story into watching a man walk toward a death we can see coming.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): An unnamed newcomer sets out alone, with only a husky dog, to walk to a mining camp on a day of extreme cold, ignoring an old-timer's warning. Themes to track: humanity versus nature.: instinct versus intelligence.: pride.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Example page. Theme: humanity versus nature. Prediction: I expect this idea to be tested when a character has to choose between what they want and what others expect. Question: what will To Build a Fire suggest about humanity versus nature by the end?
Task: Set up a reading journal for To Build a Fire: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Example page. Theme: humanity versus nature. Prediction: I expect this idea to be tested when a character has to choose between what they want and what others expect. Question: what will To Build a Fire suggest about humanity versus nature by the end?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does To Build a Fire still matter? It is a model of naturalism and of suspense from a simple plot, and a reminder to respect nature.
Anchor question: Why might To Build a Fire still be taught today?
Facilitation: It is a model of naturalism and of suspense from a simple plot, and a reminder to respect nature.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
London spent the winter of 1897–98 in the Yukon. How might seeing real cold change how he writes about it? Answer: Accept answers such as: he describes exact temperatures and their effects; he knew men who died; he respects nature's power and mocks overconfidence.
Exit ticket: London spent the winter of 1897–98 in the Yukon. How might seeing real cold change how he writes about it?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he describes exact temperatures and their effects; he knew men who died; he respects nature's power and mocks overconfidence.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: To Build a Fire.

Teacher notes · sources: Jack London State Historic Park, "Jack London" (https://jacklondonpark.com/jack-london/); Britannica, "Jack London" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Jack-London); Jack London Online Collection (Sonoma State University) (https://london.sonoma.edu/)

Lesson 2: To Build a Fire

Focus: human limits in an indifferent nature

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in "To Build a Fire" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (death by freezing, a racial slur in a period place-name compound): Sensitive content: Death by freezing; a racial slur in a period place-name compound. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death by freezing; a racial slur in a period place-name compound.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

A newcomer to the Yukon sets out alone with a wolf-dog at seventy-five below zero, ignoring an old-timer's warning never to travel alone in such cold. He breaks through ice and wets his feet, builds a fire under a snow-laden spruce, and the snow falls and puts it out. His hands freeze; he fails to light another, thinks of killing the dog for warmth, runs in panic, and freezes to death. The dog trots off toward camp.

Background: London went to the Klondike in 1897. This 1908 version (The Century) replaced a 1902 version for boys in which the man survives.

Significance: A central example of literary naturalism.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
When have you ignored good advice? What happened? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to instinct versus intelligence because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes death by freezing; a racial slur in a period place-name compound.
Prompt: When have you ignored good advice? What happened?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to instinct versus intelligence because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the dog knows what the man does not.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: avalanche — a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain; exhaled — expel air; tingling — prickling or stinging slightly; mumbled — talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice; alternate — first one and then the other. "exhaled": Origin of "exhale": Middle French exhaler; earlier Latin exhalare.
Words: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain · exhaled: expel air · tingling: prickling or stinging slightly · mumbled: talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice · alternate: first one and then the other

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
London went to the Klondike in 1897. This 1908 version (The Century) replaced a 1902 version for boys in which the man survives. A central example of literary naturalism. Point of view: An omniscient narrator knows more than the man and tells us his flaw early. Foreshadowing: The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense. Setting: The cold is the antagonist. Watch for fire: life and knowledge.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator explains that the man's real problem is that he cannot imagine what the cold might do to him. Next, craft. I notice the narrator speaks directly to us, judging the man before anything has happened. The strongest word is "imagination": it is surprising, because we expect the danger to be cold, not a lack of thinking. Then, effect. What does the narrator mean that the man is "without imagination"? My answer: The narrator means that the man notices facts but cannot imagine their consequences, so he does not respect the deadly cold; that lack of imagination will kill him.

> *The trouble with him was that he was without imagination (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator explains that the man's real problem is that he cannot imagine what the cold might do to him. Next, craft. I notice the narrator speaks directly to us, judging the man before anything has happened. The strongest word is "imagination": it is surprising, because we expect the danger to be cold, not a lack of thinking. Then, effect. What does the narrator mean that the man is "without imagination"? My answer: The narrator means that the man notices facts but cannot imagine their consequences, so he does not respect the deadly cold; that lack of imagination will kill him.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: His last admission. Look at the craft: The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense. Ask: How does this line connect to instinct versus intelligence? Expected: The dog knows what the man does not. (His last admission.)

> *You were right, old hoss; you were right* *(To Build a Fire, paragraph 40)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: His last admission. Look at the craft: The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense.
Ask: How does this line connect to instinct versus intelligence?
Expected answer: The dog knows what the man does not. (His last admission.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about human limits in an indifferent nature? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how To Build a Fire develops the idea of human limits in an indifferent nature. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. When the text says “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3), it shows this directly. The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about human limits in an indifferent nature? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how To Build a Fire develops the idea of human limits in an indifferent nature. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. When the text says “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3), it shows this directly. The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: When have you ignored good advice? What happened? Ask: was his death inevitable after his feet got wet?
Anchor question: When have you ignored good advice? What happened?
Facilitation: Ask: was his death inevitable after his feet got wet?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about human limits in an indifferent nature? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. ("The trouble with him was that he was without imagination", To Build a Fire, paragraph 3). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about human limits in an indifferent nature? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. ("The trouble with him was that he was without imagination", To Build a Fire, paragraph 3). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes human limits in an indifferent nature. Key takeaway: the dog knows what the man does not.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** An omniscient narrator knows more than the man and tells us his flaw early.
- **Foreshadowing:** The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense.
- **Setting:** The cold is the antagonist.

Themes and how they develop

- **instinct versus intelligence:** the dog knows what the man does not.

Symbols and motifs

- **fire:** life and knowledge.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3) His flaw.
- "You were right, old hoss; you were right" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40) His last admission.
- "Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41) Nature's indifference.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The man dies because he has information but no imagination.
Evidence: "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3)

Reasoning: The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
avalanche (noun)	a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain	*It grew like an avalanche, and it descended without warning upon the man and the fire, and the fire was blotted out!*	
exhaled (verb)	expel air	*The man's red beard and mustache were likewise frosted, but more solidly, the deposit taking the form of ice and increasing with every warm, moist breath he exhaled.*	“exhaled”: Origin of “exhale”: Middle French exhaler; earlier Latin exhalare. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/exhale#Etymology)
tingling (verb)	prickling or stinging slightly	*The faint tingling grew stronger till it evolved into a stinging ache that was excruciating, but which the man hailed with satisfaction.*	
mumbled (verb)	talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice	*"You were right, old hoss; you were right," the man mumbled to the old-timer of Sulphur Creek.*	
alternate (adjective)	first one and then the other	*Sometimes there were alternate layers of water and ice-skin, so that when one broke through he kept on breaking through for a while, sometimes wetting himself to the waist.*	
regained (verb)	get or find back; recover the use of	*As he sat and regained his breath, he noted that he was feeling quite warm and comfortable.*	“regained”: Origin of “regain”: Middle French regaigner. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/regain#Etymology)
repeatedly (adverb)	several time	*He struck the fingers repeatedly and returned them to the mitten, baring the other hand for the purpose of eating.*	
delayed (verb)	cause to be slowed down or delayed	*A little longer it delayed, howling under the stars that leaped and danced and shone brightly in the cold sky.*	
calmness (noun)	steadiness of mind under stress	*The man sat up in the snow for a moment and struggled for calmness.*	
		Once, coming around a bend, he shied abruptly, like a startled horse, curved	

retreated (verb)	pull back or move away or backward	*away from the place where he had been walking, and retreated several paces back along the trail.*	

Discussion questions

1. When have you ignored good advice? What happened?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with nature's indifference?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How cold is it? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: About seventy-five degrees below zero
2. What advice did the old-timer from Sulphur Creek give? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Never travel alone below fifty below
3. What puts out the man's first big fire? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Snow falling from the spruce tree above
4. What does the dog rely on? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Instinct
5. What does the dog do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Heads toward the camp and other food-providers
6. Retell the three most important events of “To Build a Fire” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A newcomer to the Yukon sets out alone with a wolf-dog at seventy-five below zero, ignoring an old-timer's warning never to travel alone in such cold. He breaks through ice and wets his feet, builds a fire under a snow-laden spruce, and the snow falls and puts it out. His hands freeze; he fails to light another, thinks of killing the dog for warmth, runs in panic, and freezes to death. The dog…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “To Build a Fire”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “To Build a Fire” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “It grew like an avalanche, and it descended without warning upon the man and the fire, and the fire was blotted out!” What does “avalanche” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain.

10. Reread: “The man's red beard and mustache were likewise frosted, but more solidly, the deposit taking the form of ice and increasing with every warm, moist breath he exhaled.” What does “exhaled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: exhaled: expel air.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “To Build a Fire” suggest about human limits in an indifferent nature? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A central example of literary naturalism.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the conflict in this story shape what we understand about human limits in an indifferent nature? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3): His flaw. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Day had broken cold and gray, exceedingly cold and gray, when the man turned aside from the main Yukon trail and climbed the high earth-bank, where a dim and little-travelled…”, why might London have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “To Build a Fire”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A newcomer to the Yukon sets out alone with a wolf-dog at seventy-five below zero, ignoring an old-timer's warning never to travel alone in such cold. He breaks through ice and wets his feet, builds a fire under a snow-laden spruce, and the snow falls and puts it out. His hands freeze; he fails to…
6. As the opening story, what does “To Build a Fire” set up that the rest of To Build a Fire will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “You were right, old hoss; you were right” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40): His last admission. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41): Nature's indifference. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: "When have you ignored good advice? What happened?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with nature's indifference? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3): His flaw. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: London went to the Klondike in 1897. This 1908 version (The Century) replaced a 1902 version for boys in which the man survives. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: "You were right, old hoss; you were right" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40): His last admission. On setting: The cold is the antagonist. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A central example of literary naturalism." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: "Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41): Nature's indifference. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3): His flaw. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "To Build a Fire" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about human limits in an indifferent nature? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: "You were right, old hoss; you were right" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40): His last admission. On point of view: An omniscient narrator knows more than the man and tells us his flaw early. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “To Build a Fire”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41): Nature's indifference. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to instinct versus reason: is the link strong or weak so far? What would London need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3): His flaw. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “You were right, old hoss; you were right” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40): His last admission. On setting: The cold is the antagonist. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “To Build a Fire” treats human limits in an indifferent nature with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does To Build a Fire see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41): Nature's indifference. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve nature's indifference? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3): His flaw. On foreshadowing: The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about human limits in an indifferent nature? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “You were right, old hoss; you were right” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40):

His last admission. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Jack London about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Useful evidence: “Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41): Nature's indifference. Theme link: the dog knows what the man does not. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What advice did the old-timer from Sulphur Creek give?

   A. Always carry a gun

   B. Never travel alone below fifty below

   C. Follow the river

   D. Leave the dog behind

   Key: B (Never travel alone below fifty below)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from To Build a Fire, paragraph 41: “Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the _____ of the camp it knew”

   Key: direction

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “A little longer it _____, howling under the stars that leaped and danced and shone brightly in the cold sky.” Word bank: tingling, exhaled, avalanche, delayed

   Key: delayed

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What puts out the man's first big fire?

   A. Water from the creek

   B. Wind

   C. Snow falling from the spruce tree above

   D. The dog

   Key: C (Snow falling from the spruce tree above)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “As he sat and _____ his breath, he noted that he was feeling quite warm and comfortable.” Word bank: avalanche, tingling, exhaled, regained

   Key: regained

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the dog do at the end?

   A. Stays by the man

   B. Howls until rescued

   C. Runs into the woods

   D. Heads toward the camp and other food-providers

   Key: D (Heads toward the camp and other food-providers)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He struck the fingers _____ and returned them to the mitten, baring the other hand for the purpose of eating." Word bank: exhaled, avalanche, tingling, repeatedly

   Key: repeatedly

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Sometimes there were _____ layers of water and ice-skin, so that when one broke through he kept on breaking through for a while, sometimes wetting himself to the waist." Word bank: alternate, exhaled, tingling, avalanche

   Key: alternate

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from To Build a Fire, paragraph 3: "The trouble with him was that he was without _____"

   Key: imagination

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the dog rely on?

    A. The man's orders

    B. Instinct

    C. A map

    D. Reason

    Key: B (Instinct)

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "To Build a Fire"?

    A. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

    B. A family and a house collapsing together

    C. Waking into a changed nation

    D. Human limits in an indifferent nature

    Key: D (Human limits in an indifferent nature)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "You were right, old hoss; you were right" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His last admission.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His flaw.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "To Build a Fire"? The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense.

    A. Plot

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Allusion

    D. Setting

Key: B (Foreshadowing)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3).
    Sample answer: The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how instinct versus intelligence develops from an earlier story to “To Build a Fire”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: the dog knows what the man does not.
17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Nature's indifference.
18. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “To Build a Fire”? An omniscient narrator knows more than the man and tells us his flaw early.
    A. Conflict
    B. Point of view
    C. Simile
    D. Imagery

    Key: B (Point of view)
19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How cold is it?
    A. About seventy-five degrees below zero
    B. Forty above
    C. Freezing, thirty-two degrees
    D. Ten below

    Key: A (About seventy-five degrees below zero)
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His flaw.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The man dies because he has information but no imagination.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “You were right, old hoss; you were right” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His last admission.
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It grew like an avalanche, and it descended without warning upon the man and the fire, and the fire was blotted out!”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?
    A. expel air
    B. prickling or stinging slightly
    C. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

Key: D (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"You were right, old hoss; you were right," the man mumbled to the old-timer of Sulphur Creek.”, what does “mumbled” most nearly mean?

A. prickling or stinging slightly

B. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

C. expel air

D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

Key: B (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The faint tingling grew stronger till it evolved into a stinging ache that was excruciating, but which the man hailed with satisfaction.”, what does “tingling” most nearly mean?

A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

B. prickling or stinging slightly

C. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

D. expel air

Key: B (prickling or stinging slightly)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	6, 4, 3, 9, 7, 10, 1, 5, 8, 11, 12, 13, 15, 17, 18, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 1, 4, 19, 8, 7, 3, 9, 12, 11, 13, 17, 15, 18, 16, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	7, 8, 6, 4, 1, 5, 2, 12, 11, 13, 15, 18, 17, 14, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 5, 9, 4, 7, 2, 11, 12, 13, 17, 15, 18, 14, 21, 16, 22	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	2, 3, 23, 9, 24, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 17, 18, 21, 20, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 10, 1, 2, 6, 12, 13, 11, 18, 15, 14, 17, 16, 20, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	8, 5, 23, 25, 24, 13, 12, 11, 15, 14, 18, 17, 16, 20, 21, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	25, 23, 8, 19, 5, 12, 11, 13, 14, 15, 17, 18, 22, 16, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	8, 23, 7, 10, 25, 11, 12, 13, 15, 14, 17, 18, 20, 22, 16, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	23, 24, 9, 4, 3, 12, 13, 11, 17, 14, 15, 18, 16, 22, 21, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “To Build a Fire,” how does London show human limits in an indifferent nature? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In To Build a Fire, how does London develop the idea of human limits in an indifferent nature? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how To Build a Fire develops the idea of human limits in an indifferent nature. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of To Build a Fire (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of human limits in an indifferent nature. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what To Build a Fire suggests about human limits in an indifferent nature. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Jack London uses setting in To Build a Fire to complicate the reader's understanding of human limits in an indifferent nature. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate To Build a Fire within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of human limits in an indifferent nature responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read To Build a Fire alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of human limits in an indifferent nature follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to To Build a Fire and its treatment of human limits in an indifferent nature. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads To Build a Fire as evidence for a larger claim about human limits in an indifferent nature in To Build a Fire. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads To Build a Fire as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of human limits in an indifferent nature.

Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on To Build a Fire.

SAT-style questions

1. *The faint tingling grew stronger till it evolved into a stinging ache that was excruciating, but which the man hailed with satisfaction.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "tingling" most nearly mean?

   A. steadiness of mind under stress

   B. prickling or stinging slightly

   C. pull back or move away or backward

   D. cause to be slowed down or delayed

2. *Day had broken cold and gray, exceedingly cold and gray, when the man turned aside from the main Yukon trail and climbed the high earth-bank, where a dim and little-travelled trail led eastward through the fat spruce timberland. It was a steep bank, and he paused for breath at the top, excusing the act to himself by looking at his watch. It was nine o'clock. There was no sun nor hint of sun, though there was not a cloud in the sky. It was a clear day, and yet there seemed an intangible pall over the face of things, a subtle gloom that made the day dark, and that was due to the absence of sun. This fact did not worry the man. He was used to the lack of sun. It had been days since he had seen the sun, and he knew that a few more days must pass before that cheerful orb, due south, would just peep above the sky-line and dip immediately from view.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "To Build a Fire"?

   A. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

   B. Human limits in an indifferent nature

   C. Love measured by sacrifice

   D. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

SAT key: 1. B (prickling or stinging slightly); 2. B (Human limits in an indifferent nature)

Unit test

To Build a Fire: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What advice did the old-timer from Sulphur Creek give?
   A. Always carry a gun
   B. Never travel alone below fifty below
   C. Follow the river
   D. Leave the dog behind

   Key: B (Never travel alone below fifty below)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the dog rely on?
   A. The man's orders
   B. Instinct
   C. A map
   D. Reason

   Key: B (Instinct)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What puts out the man's first big fire?
   A. Water from the creek
   B. Wind
   C. Snow falling from the spruce tree above
   D. The dog

   Key: C (Snow falling from the spruce tree above)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from To Build a Fire, paragraph 3: “The trouble with him was that he was without _____”

   Key: imagination
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the dog do at the end?
   A. Stays by the man
   B. Howls until rescued
   C. Runs into the woods
   D. Heads toward the camp and other food-providers

Key: D (Heads toward the camp and other food-providers)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Sometimes there were _____ layers of water and ice-skin, so that when one broke through he kept on breaking through for a while, sometimes wetting himself to the waist." Word bank: alternate, exhaled, tingling, avalanche

   Key: alternate

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from To Build a Fire, paragraph 41: "Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the _____ of the camp it knew"

   Key: direction

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He struck the fingers _____ and returned them to the mitten, baring the other hand for the purpose of eating." Word bank: exhaled, avalanche, tingling, repeatedly

   Key: repeatedly

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "As he sat and _____ his breath, he noted that he was feeling quite warm and comfortable." Word bank: avalanche, tingling, exhaled, regained

   Key: regained

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "A little longer it _____, howling under the stars that leaped and danced and shone brightly in the cold sky." Word bank: tingling, exhaled, avalanche, delayed

    Key: delayed

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How cold is it?

    A. About seventy-five degrees below zero

    B. Forty above

    C. Freezing, thirty-two degrees

    D. Ten below

    Key: A (About seventy-five degrees below zero)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His flaw.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "You were right, old hoss; you were right" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: His last admission.

14. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "To Build a Fire"?

    A. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

    B. A family and a house collapsing together

    C. Waking into a changed nation

    D. Human limits in an indifferent nature

    Key: D (Human limits in an indifferent nature)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in "Then it turned and trotted up the trail in the direction of the camp it knew" (To Build a Fire, paragraph 41). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Nature's indifference.

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “To Build a Fire”? The old-timer's warning and each mistake build suspense.

    A. Plot

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Allusion

    D. Setting

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The man dies because he has information but no imagination. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3).

    Sample answer: The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The trouble with him was that he was without imagination” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 3) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: His flaw.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The man dies because he has information but no imagination.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The narrator says "The trouble with him was that he was without imagination"; only at death does he admit "You were right, old hoss," and the dog "trotted up the trail," indifferent.

20. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “To Build a Fire”? An omniscient narrator knows more than the man and tells us his flaw early.

    A. Conflict

    B. Point of view

    C. Simile

    D. Imagery

    Key: B (Point of view)

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how instinct versus intelligence develops from an earlier story to “To Build a Fire”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the dog knows what the man does not.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “You were right, old hoss; you were right” (To Build a Fire, paragraph 40) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: His last admission.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The faint tingling grew stronger till it evolved into a stinging ache that was excruciating, but which the man hailed with satisfaction.”, what does “tingling” most nearly mean?

    A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    B. prickling or stinging slightly

    C. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    D. expel air

    Key: B (prickling or stinging slightly)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line ""You were right, old hoss; you were right," the man mumbled to the old-timer of Sulphur Creek.", what does "mumbled" most nearly mean?

    A. prickling or stinging slightly

    B. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    C. expel air

    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    Key: B (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The man's red beard and mustache were likewise frosted, but more solidly, the deposit taking the form of ice and increasing with every warm, moist breath he exhaled.", what does "exhaled" most nearly mean?

    A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    C. expel air

    D. prickling or stinging slightly

    Key: C (expel air)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It grew like an avalanche, and it descended without warning upon the man and the fire, and the fire was blotted out!", what does "avalanche" most nearly mean?

    A. expel air

    B. prickling or stinging slightly

    C. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain

    Key: D (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	10, 9, 3, 7, 8, 4, 5, 6, 11, 2, 1, 13, 12, 14, 15, 16, 17, 19	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 3, 1, 2, 9, 5, 7, 6, 4, 11, 12, 14, 13, 15, 20, 16, 18, 19	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 2, 4, 10, 11, 9, 1, 7, 3, 14, 12, 13, 16, 20, 15, 17, 19, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 10, 7, 9, 5, 3, 1, 4, 12, 13, 14, 16, 17, 20, 15, 22, 19, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	23, 8, 3, 9, 4, 24, 25, 12, 13, 14, 17, 15, 16, 20, 21, 19, 18, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	25, 24, 4, 1, 8, 23, 3, 12, 13, 14, 20, 16, 17, 15, 18, 21, 22, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	24, 10, 6, 5, 2, 1, 9, 14, 12, 13, 17, 15, 16, 20, 19, 18, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Junior	4, 24, 5, 9, 8, 6, 2, 14, 13, 12, 20, 17, 16, 15, 22, 19, 18, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	26, 7, 5, 3, 25, 8, 4, 12, 13, 14, 15, 17, 20, 16, 21, 19, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	8, 7, 23, 4, 5, 9, 3, 12, 13, 14, 20, 16, 17, 15, 18, 21, 19, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

To Build a Fire: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Jack London develops nature's indifference across To Build a Fire. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in To Build a Fire and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to instinct versus reason.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in To Build a Fire. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether To Build a Fire finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of pride. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Nature's indifference

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what To Build a Fire teaches about nature's indifference. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops nature's indifference in To Build a Fire. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops nature's indifference across To Build a Fire. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of To Build a Fire (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature's indifference. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature's indifference in To Build a Fire. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in To Build a Fire (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature's indifference, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places To Build a Fire's treatment of nature's indifference in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature's indifference in To Build a Fire that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature's indifference in To Build a Fire. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature's indifference in To Build a Fire, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature's indifference in To Build a Fire, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Instinct versus reason

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what To Build a Fire teaches about instinct versus reason. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops instinct versus reason in To Build a Fire. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops instinct versus reason across To Build a Fire. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of To Build a Fire (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of instinct versus reason. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of instinct versus reason in To Build a Fire. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in To Build a Fire (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of instinct versus reason, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places To Build a Fire's treatment of instinct versus reason in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on instinct versus reason in To Build a Fire that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on instinct versus reason in To Build a Fire. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about instinct versus reason in To Build a Fire, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on instinct versus reason in To Build a Fire, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Pride

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what To Build a Fire teaches about pride. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jack London develops pride in To Build a Fire. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jack London develops pride across To Build a Fire. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of To Build a Fire (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of pride. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of pride in To Build a Fire. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jack London's choices in To Build a Fire (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of pride, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places To Build a Fire's treatment of pride in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on pride in To Build a Fire that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on pride in To Build a Fire. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on pride in To Build a Fire, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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